

Variation and Historical Change

When we study a language it is important not only to look at its structure (phonology, morphology, syntax, and semantics), but also how the language is used. Human beings use language every day in a variety of social settings and for a variety of reasons. Ralph Fasold (1984), a sociolinguist, pointed out that while we do use language to communicate information to each other, we also use language to define the social situation; in other words we use language to make our social and cultural identity clear, to show our group loyalties, to explain our relationships to other people, and to describe what kind of event we think we are involved in. Language, therefore, has different functions: it has communicative functions and it has social functions.

Dell Hymes, an anthropologist, introduced the concept of *communicative competence*. According to Hymes (1972), when someone knows a language, he or she knows how to use the forms of the language; knows the phonology, morphology, and syntax of the language; and knows how to use the language appropriately. This means the person knows how to enter or leave a conversation properly, what kind of language to use for a request or an apology, what kind of language is appropriate for different social situations, and so forth. When a user of a language is communicatively competent, he or she knows how to use language for both communicative and social functions.

Sociolinguistics is the study of the interrelationship of language and social structure. Sociolinguists study variation in language, contact between languages, language planning and policy, language attitudes, and the relationship between social interaction and language, including the structure of conversation. In this section, we will provide an introduction to three major areas of sociolinguistics—variation, discourse, and bilingualism and language contact.

VARIATION

Variation in language means that people have different ways of saying the same thing. The earliest studies of variation in language focused on *regional variation*. People in one geographic area may use a language differently from people in

another geographic area, even though the language they are using has the same name. For example, in the United States, many regional differences are found in the vocabulary of spoken English. Some people use the word *sofa*, while others say *couch*, and still others say *davenport*; some people say *soda*, while others say *pop* or *coke* or *soft drink*; some people say *bag* while others say *sack* or *poke*; some people use the word *supper* while others use *dinner*, and so forth.

Regional differences can also be found in the phonological system of the language. Those differences may be referred to as *accents*. For example, someone from Boston may have a New England accent, while someone from Atlanta may have a southern accent. This simply means that certain sounds in the speaker's phonological system are consistently produced in a way that is different from the sounds in another speaker's phonological system. A speaker from Boston may say the *a* in the words *car* and *father* differently from a Chicagoan, and the Boston speaker may not produce the *r* in either word. There also may be some morphological and syntactical regional differences.

Variation is not limited to regional variation. Other kinds of variation include *social* variation, *ethnic* variation, *gender* variation, and *age* variation. For example, people from different socioeconomic groups within the same society may speak differently—differences have been described between working-class and middle-class speakers of American English. African American people may speak differently from white people, men may speak differently from women, and old people may speak differently from young people.

The same kind of variation exists in American Sign Language. We see variation at all levels of ASL structure: phonological variation, morphological variation, and lexical variation. Many examples of lexical variation have been documented. Ask a group of native ASL signers to show you their signs for PICNIC, BIRTHDAY, HALLOWEEN, EARLY, and SOON and you will see examples of regional variation (see Figure 95). Some of the variation exists because, in the past, deaf students attended the residential school in their region and did not have much contact with signers from other areas. Another reason for variation is that ASL was not formally taught or even recognized in the schools.

Despite the variations in ASL, it seems to be somewhat more standardized than other sign languages. Italian Sign Language (LIS), for example, seems to have much more regional variation than ASL. This may be because in the early decades of deaf education in the United States, many teachers, both deaf and hearing, came to the American School for the Deaf in Hartford, Connecticut, from all over the country to learn Laurent Clerc's teaching method. They then returned to their schools. Many graduates of the school in Hartford established schools for the deaf in other parts of the country. As a result, both the teachers and the graduates took with them the ASL they had learned in Hartford. Not so in Italy, where there were few centralized schools and where only fairly recently the deaf communities in the different cities have begun to have contact. For a long time the many deaf communities were isolated from each other, each with its own sign language, and no attempt was made by school administrators to establish contact among students in schools for the deaf. The result is a lot of regional differences.

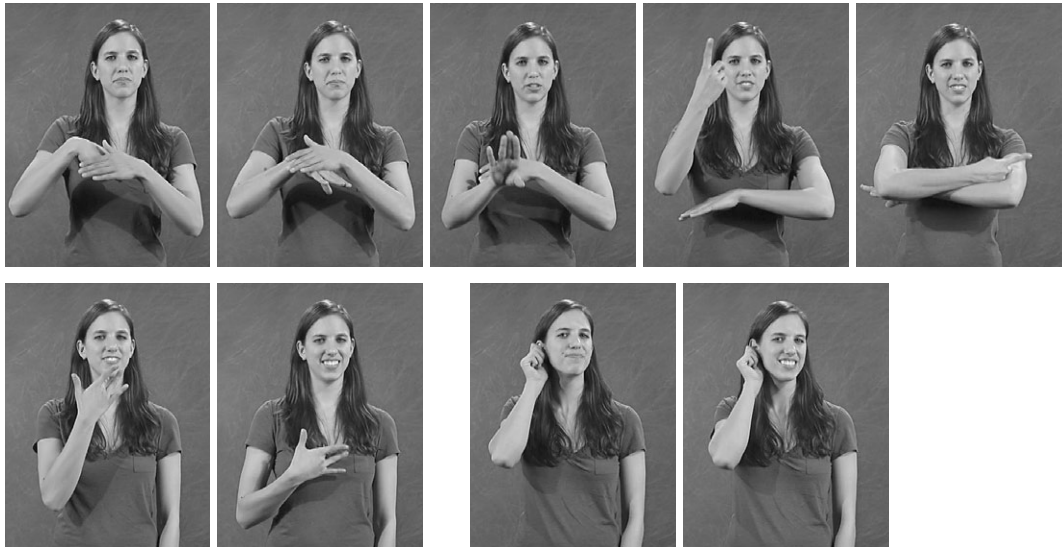


Figure 95. Regional variations of BIRTHDAY.



Figure 96. Ethnic variations of SCHOOL.

ASL also has ethnic variations. Anthony Aramburo has found that Black signers and White signers use different signs for SCHOOL, BOSS, and FLIRT (see SCHOOL in Figure 96). This variation is probably due to isolation and lack of contact between Black and White Deaf communities as a result of segregated education. Research on the ASL used by Black signers has been done by Jeff Lewis (1997) and by Carolyn McCaskill, Ceil Lucas, Robert Bayley, and Joseph Hill (2011). The latter study examined whether the same kind of linguistic features that have been identified for African American English (AAE) could be identified for Black ASL. The first school for Black deaf children was established in North Carolina in 1869, and separate schools or departments opened in 16 other southern states and the District of Columbia. The Southern School for Deaf Negroes (SSD) in Louisiana was the last to open, in 1938, and the last to close, in 1978. The researchers interviewed people over the age of 55 who had gone to segregated schools and people under 35 who went to integrated schools, in 6 of the 17 states. The researchers found that

there are features that define Black ASL as a distinct variety and also that, because of integrated schooling, this variety seems to be changing. On the DVD, you can see clips of signers from the six states included in the study.

Research has also been done on the sign language used by Navajo Indians in Arizona (Davis and Supalla 1995) and on the Tactile ASL used by deaf-blind people (Collins 2004; Collins and Petronio 1998; Haas, Fleetwood, and Ernest 1995). These studies have revealed some interesting variation patterns.

Signers also report gender variation, that is, differences between the way men and women sign, although this is an area that still needs to be researched. And there are also age differences, such that older signers may have ways of signing that differ from younger signers. Students often report forms of signs that they have seen used by older friends and relatives. This brings us to the issue of historical change.

HISTORICAL CHANGE

As we said, variation means a different way of saying the same thing. Often, the same person will have different ways of saying the same thing and will make a choice depending on the situation. And often the different forms will stay in the language indefinitely. But many times, a change in an existing form will be introduced, or a whole new form will appear. The old form and the new form may coexist for a while, and then the old form may disappear. This process is called *historical change*.

Historical change in languages often takes place in the vocabulary and in the phonology, but some changes may happen in the morphology and syntax as well. An example from spoken languages is the evolution from Latin to the Romance languages (French, Italian, Spanish, Portuguese, and Romanian). The changes in Latin were the result of the passage of a great deal of time and social change. However, if we were able to visit what is now France in the year A.D. 800, we would see that older speakers in a given community on a given day in the marketplace spoke differently from younger speakers. For them at that moment in time, it would simply look like variation (i.e., “we have different ways of saying the same thing”). From our modern perspective, it looks like historical change. Gradual changes in all parts of the language took place over a very long period of time, such that modern French is completely different from the Latin that is its base.

Researchers such as Nancy Frishberg, James Woodward, Carol Erting, and Susan DeSantis have described historical change in ASL, and other researchers such as Emily Shaw and Yves Delaporte have described historical change in other sign languages. Many ASL signs bear a close resemblance to French Sign Language (LSF) signs because Clerc was a signer of LSF. We can see evidence of historical change from LSF to ASL. For example, signs such as CAT, COW, HORSE, and DEVIL that were produced with two hands in LSF are produced with one hand in ASL. Some LSF signs that were produced on the elbow (HELP and GUIDE) are now produced on the weak hand in ASL.

Some changes have occurred as a result of assimilation, where the handshape of one hand has become like the handshape of the other. In an older form of the

sign TOMATO, the dominant hand is a l handshape while the passive hand is an O handshape. Over time, the passive handshape has become a l. We see this with other signs as well, such as LAST, BELIEVE, and HUSBAND. Sometimes the location feature of a sign changes with time, as in the sign WRONG, which in an older form was produced on the mouth and is now produced on the chin; or the sign FEEL, the location of which has moved from the left side of the chest to the middle. And while some signs have changed from being two-handed to one-handed, others such as DIE and JOURNEY have changed from being one-handed to two-handed. These are all examples of historical change in ASL.

DOCUMENTING CHANGE IN ASL

One of the unique characteristics of language is that it changes over time, and the change is continual. We can see evidence of some of the changes that occurred in ASL during the twentieth century by watching George Veditz sign “Preservation of the Sign Language” on the DVD. Veditz, a graduate of Gallaudet College, was a respected teacher and leader in the Deaf community. He taught at both the Maryland and Colorado Schools for the Deaf and served two terms as president of the National Association of the Deaf. In this speech, given in 1913, he expresses his concern for the need to preserve sign languages in the face of strong pressures from educators who endorsed oral-only communication for deaf children.

We also can see changes going on right now with the introduction of new terms for *telephone*, *television*, and *computer technology*. For example, the different signs that exist for *computer* reflect both regional differences and changes in technology. Similarly, the sign for changing channels on a television, an iconic sign of a hand turning the channel knob, is being replaced by a newer sign that is an iconic representation of a remote control.

The older form of HOME was a compound consisting of the signs EAT and SLEEP. The handshape of SLEEP assimilated to the EAT handshape, and the location of EAT assimilated to the SLEEP location. It is not uncommon now to see a form of the sign HOME that touches the cheek twice in the same location on the lower cheek. As we said, language is always changing.

Ceil Lucas, Robert Bayley, and Clayton Valli, with the participation of Mary Rose, Alyssa Wulf, Paul Dudis, Susan Schatz, and Laurie Sanheim, conducted an extensive study of variation in ASL (2001). Their seven-year project targeted seven sites in the United States—Staunton, Virginia; Frederick, Maryland; Boston; New Orleans; Kansas City, Missouri; Fremont, California; and Bellingham, Washington. In all, they videotaped 207 ASL users engaged in everyday conversation. The study looked at phonological variation in signs made with a l handshape (recall the discussion of assimilation in unit 7), variation in the sign DEAF (signed from ear to chin, from chin to ear, or as a single contact on the cheek; recall the discussion of metathesis in unit 7), and variation in the location of signs such as THINK, KNOW, and SUPPOSE, which are produced on the forehead in citation form but can move down and be produced below the forehead.

The researchers' original hypothesis was that the variation observed in all three variables could be explained by phonological factors (that is, the characteristics of the location or handshape of the preceding or following signs). But when they analyzed almost 10,000 examples of the three variables (1,618 for DEAF, 2,862 for location signs, and 5,356 for 1 handshape signs), they found that while phonological variables do show some effect, the major factor in explaining the variation is the grammatical function of the sign. Specifically, DEAF can function as an adjective, noun, or predicate, and the noncitation forms (chin-to-ear or contact-cheek) are much more likely to be adjectives, while the citation form (ear-to-chin) is more likely to be a predicate. With location signs, verbs favor citation forms (at the forehead), while function words like prepositions favor the lower noncitation forms. First-person pronouns favor noncitation 1 handshapes (thumb open or all fingers open) second person is neutral, and third-person pronouns and content signs (nouns and verbs) favor citation forms (thumb and all fingers except index closed).

The study also found correlations with social factors. For example, with the sign DEAF, younger and older signers in general favor the chin-to-ear form, while middle-age signers favor the ear-to-chin form. Signers from Boston and Maryland strongly prefer the ear-to-chin form, while signers from the other areas are neutral or prefer the chin-to-ear form. And while older signers prefer the forehead level for the location signs, younger signers prefer the lower forms.

Morphosyntactic variation includes the dropping of subject pronouns with verbs that usually require a subject, such as FEEL, KNOW, and LIKE. Lucas et al. (2001) looked at plain verbs (verbs that do not include any information about the subject) and found that these verbs are more likely to occur without a signed pronoun than with one. Key factors in accounting for the variation are switch reference (whether the subject of the target verb is the same as the immediately preceding subject or different), the person and number of the pronoun (a first-person pronoun is more likely to be signed than other pronouns), and English influence (a pronoun is more likely to occur in a more English-like sentence). Older signers and women are more likely to produce pronoun subjects than omit them.

Lucas et al. (2001) also studied lexical variation by asking signers to demonstrate their sign for 34 separate concepts, such as RABBIT, COMPUTER, AFRICA, and JAPAN. They found a distinction between lexical innovation and phonological variation. For example, the new signs for AFRICA and JAPAN are lexical innovations and these new signs have been adopted by all age groups in all seven regions of the study. The old and new variants of signs like RABBIT (the old sign produced at the forehead and the new sign made on the hands in neutral space) are used by all age groups, indicating that while change may be in progress, it is not a completed change. If the change were completed, we would expect younger signers to use only the newer forms. This project shows that ASL, like other languages, has sociolinguistic variation, with both linguistic and social factors accounting for the variation. The Black ASL project (McCaskill et al. 2011) revealed similar results. The signers interviewed demonstrated many signs unique to the Black community and also unique to their geographical areas.

SUPPLEMENTAL READINGS

Files 10.1, 10.2, and 10.3 from *Language Files: Materials for an Introduction to Language and Linguistics* (2004); pp. 459–469

“Analyzing Variation in Sign Languages: Theoretical and Methodological Issues,” by Rob Hoopes, Mary Rose, Robert Bayley, Ceil Lucas, Alyssa Wulf, Karen Petronio, and Steven Collins (2000); pp. 470–491

“Variation in American Sign Language,” by Ceil Lucas and Robert Bayley (2010); pp. 492–511

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- McCaskill, C., Lucas, C., Bayley, R., and Hill, J. 2011. *The hidden treasure of Black ASL: Its history and structure*. Washington, DC: Gallaudet University Press.
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- Woodward, J. C., and DeSantis, S. 1977. Two to one it happens: Dynamic phonology in two sign languages. *Sign Language Studies* 17: 29–46.
- Woodward, J. C., and Erting, C. 1975. Synchronic variation and historical change in American Sign Language. *Language Sciences* 37: 9–12.

Homework Assignment 18

1. Find and list as many examples as you can of signs that vary from region to region. Are the signs completely different or are they basically the same, with variation only in handshape or location or palm orientation? Do you see any signs in the Kansas and Louisiana conversations or in the ASL PAH! stories that are different from the signs you use?
2. Find and list examples of signs that older and younger people use differently and discuss the differences you see. One area in which you might find differences are in the signs for countries.
3. Watch "Preservation of the Sign Language" on the DVD. This clip is taken from a speech George Veditz made to the National Association of the Deaf in 1913. As you watch the speech, you will see many examples of the differences between ASL in 1913 and now. List as many of the differences as you can find and classify them. For example, are the differences in parts of signs or in whole signs?

“Louisiana Conversation.” From the NSF Sociolinguistic Variation Project conducted at Gallaudet University, 1994–2001.

“My Favorite Old Summer House,” signed by Clayton Valli, from Clayton Valli, *Poetry in Motion: Original Works in ASL* (Burtonsville, MD: Sign Media Inc., 1990). Used by permission.

“Dandelions,” signed by Clayton Valli, from Clayton Valli, *Poetry in Motion: Original Works in ASL* (Burtonsville, MD: Sign Media Inc., 1990). Used by permission.

The DVD content is available online on the Gallaudet University Press YouTube channel: **[youtube.com/GallaudetUniversityPress](https://www.youtube.com/GallaudetUniversityPress)**.

Under Playlists, click "Linguistics of American Sign Language (5th edition) DVD."